

DANCE

Holding Court

The legendary dancer Rukmini Devi Arundale was an innovator in the dance-drama genre in the 1940s. Today, dancers interpret classical texts and adapt them to modern themes when they perform. The American-born Bharatnatyam dancer, Justin McCarthy, who teaches at the Shri Ram Bharatiya Kala Kendra in Delhi, was drawn to the art form since his early training at The Way of the Dance in Berkeley. McCarthy later learnt Bharatnatyam under Subbaraya Pillai at Chennai and Leela Samson. Being a musician allows him to compose the music for his choreographic works as well. His choreographed *Kshetranya*, an imagined life of a poet-musician, was a hit. In his latest production, *Rajavilasam—Splendours of the Courtesans* presented by Gati Forum, he locates

Bharatnatyam in the courtly context, reimagining how the dance and the dancer may have behaved under the royal patrons. He has explored the chemistry between the protagonists—the kings and courtesans. Their love stories and daily rituals form the basis of movement for these sequences. The period's music and poetry form the soundscapes for this production. Presented in an intimate space, *Rajavilasam* delineates some of the luxuriant layers of royal love. It will be presented by six dancers and four musicians. "I have tried to capture the period's ambience through court scenes, including some of kings being entertained by courtesans," says McCarthy. On January 23 and 24 at the Max Mueller Bhavan and on January 31 at India Habitat Centre.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit

JUSTIN MCCARTHY
(CENTRE)



A WORK BY
BALAKA

ART EXHIBITION

Getting to Know A CITY

Balaka Bhattacharya's work mirrors the influence of her father, Bikash Bhattacharya. Her recent exhibition *Sidesteps* is a narration of the emotional state of a city as it has been personified. The canvases in this exhibition are hung from the ceiling and recordings of urban sounds playing in the background complete the ambience. The paintings are combinations of photographs and paints, where the photographic part portrays reality and the painted symbolises the surreal. The artist, who did her masters from the University College for the Creative Arts, Canterbury, UK, has described the stress and strain that a city undergoes and where personal aspirations are often thwarted by constant competition. The city emerges as a being where the inner layer shows people mesmerised and the outer is the result of harsh reality. On January 22, at Gallery Sanskriti, Kolkata.

by Elora Sen